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Common Yellowthroat

Geothlypis trichas

QUICK STATS

Length	4.3 – 5.1 in (11 – 13 cm)
Wingspan	5.9 – 7.5 in (15 – 19 cm)
Weight	0.3 – 0.3 oz (9 – 10 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 1–2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Common Yellowthroat is one of the most widespread and abundant warblers in North America — a small, energetic bird of marshes, wet thickets, and weedy fields whose masked male is instantly recognizable. The bold black mask bordered by white above, vivid yellow throat, and olive-green back give the male an almost comical appearance — like a tiny, feathered bandit. Its loud, emphatic song — "witchety-witchety-witchety" — is one of the most familiar sounds of summer wetlands and overgrown fields across the continent, and is often the first warbler song a beginning birder learns to identify by ear.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Common Yellowthroat breeds across virtually all of North America, from Alaska and Canada south through the entire United States to Mexico, making it one of the most broadly distributed warblers on the continent. It winters along the Gulf Coast, in Florida, and through Central America. It inhabits a wide variety of dense, low vegetation near water: cattail marshes, sedge meadows, wet thickets, stream margins, and overgrown fields. It is rarely found far from dense, low cover — it is a skulker by nature.

DIET & FEEDING

- Insects — the near-exclusive diet: beetles, flies, ants, aphids
- Caterpillars and moth larvae gleaned from low vegetation
- Spiders and small invertebrates from dense stem bases
- Damselflies and small dragonflies near wetland edges
- Occasionally small seeds in late summer and fall
- Does not visit feeders — dense native plantings near water attract it

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The Common Yellowthroat is a restless, secretive bird that spends most of its time moving through dense low vegetation just above the water line — difficult to observe but easy to hear. Males are highly territorial and respond aggressively to playback of their song, often popping up to a visible perch to investigate an intruder. The black mask of the male is a social signal used in mate assessment and male rivalry. Females choose nesting sites within the male's territory and are largely responsible for nest construction. Outside the breeding season, yellowthroats are often found in loose mixed flocks during migration.

NESTING & BREEDING

The female builds a bulky, deep cup nest of grasses, sedges, and plant fibers, placed low in dense vegetation — often within inches of the ground or water surface, attached to cattail stems or grass clumps. She incubates 3–5 white eggs with reddish-brown spots for 12 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 8–10 days. Pairs raise 1–2 broods per season. The Common Yellowthroat is a frequent cowbird host, and cowbird parasitism can significantly reduce nesting success.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Common Yellowthroat's song is one of the most distinctive in North America — a loud, emphatic "witchety-witchety-witchety" repeated 3–5 times, carrying well across open marsh and weedy fields. Geographic variation in song is extensive; local dialects differ across the continent. The call is a sharp, dry "tchek" — frequently given as the bird moves through dense cover. The song is heard from May through August on breeding grounds.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Common Yellowthroat population is estimated at 73 million individuals but has declined by approximately 38% since 1970, driven primarily by the draining and degradation of wetlands and the loss of dense, shrubby riparian habitat. It is highly sensitive to wetland quality. Protecting and restoring wetland edges, marshes, and dense riparian thickets are the most effective conservation actions for this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Common Yellowthroats do not visit feeders — habitat is the key
- Plant native cattails, sedges, and willows near any water feature
- A garden pond with dense emergent vegetation may attract nesting pairs
- Listen for 'witchety-witchety' in May near any wet, weedy area
- Dense native shrubs near water provide essential cover during migration

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Throat & breast (male)	Bright yellow
Black mask (male)	Bold, bordered above by white
Back & wings	Olive-green
Belly & flanks	Yellow-buff, fading to whitish
Female — face	Plain olive — no mask
Bill	Short, slender, dark — warbler style

COLOR ME!

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